

NOOR POST

One of fourteen. Open it on the day.



FOR

[Child's name]



Noor Post

[Return address – not set]

**ENVELOPE 11 ·
RAMADAN · INSIDE THE
FLAP**

Open together.

 **About twenty-five
minutes**

● is the grown-up. ○ is you.

- 1 The letter – read it out loud, ● and ○ taking turns
- 2 The hadith card
- 3 The prints
- 4 Open the case file
- 5 The stickers
- 6 The postcard



FACT PANEL

Imam Ali al-Hadi

(peace be upon him)

B. 212 AH, NEAR MEDINA • D. 254 AH, SAMARRA

- **Where and when.** Born near Medina, made to move to Samarra as a young man, and there for the rest of his life. He is buried in the city he was brought to.
- **Who was ruling.** The Abbasid caliphs from Samarra, beginning with al-Mutawakkil – the one who sent the soldiers. The throne changed hands violently several times while he was there.
- **The imamate.** About thirty-three years, from 220 AH, from the age of about eight. **The second child imam in this box** – his father, in envelope 14, was about the same age.
- **What he left.** Students, and the ziyarat attributed to him that is still read at shrines by people who do not know whose words they are using. Also the machinery: the network of representatives he and his son ran from inside a garrison town.
- **Samana.** His mother. The accounts describe her as devout and as the one who raised him through the years the family was under closest watch – a childhood spent being observed, run by her.
- **Elsewhere in the world.** In the same years, in China, someone printed a book – a copy of the Diamond Sutra, dated to 868 CE, and the oldest printed book anywhere with a date on it.

He died in Samarra in 254 AH, after more than twenty years held in that city. Shia accounts hold that he was killed on the orders of the caliph of the day.

ENVELOPE 11 • RAMADAN

What They Found in the House

● is the grown-up • ○ is you • ●○ is together

- Soldiers came to the house at night. Not a knock. They came over the wall and through the door at the same time, in the dark, the way you do it when you expect the person inside to be hiding something.

○ How many?

- Enough to surround a house. And they had been told what to look for. Weapons. Letters. Money for an army. Men gathered in a back room planning something.

○ Who sent them?

- The caliph. His name was al-Mutawakkil, he ruled from Samarra, and he had an army, a treasury and every judge in the empire.
- They went through the house room by room. And in one of the rooms they found a man sitting on the floor, in the dark, on nothing but a mat, wearing rough wool, praying.

○ Was he pretending?

- They had come without warning, in the middle of the night. Nobody had time to arrange anything.
- So they searched the rest. Then they went back and told the caliph the truth, which was that there was nothing there. No weapons. No plans. No plot. A man, a mat and a room. Nothing worth writing down, and they had been sent out to write something down.

○ **Then he was safe?**

- He was moved to Samarra to live where the army lived, and he stayed there for about twenty years, and he was not left alone once in all that time.

○ **Why bother, if there was nothing there?**

- That is the question, and I am not answering it. It is in the envelope, sealed.
- Think about it properly. Here is a ruler with soldiers in every city and gold in a vault, sending men over a wall at night after somebody who owns a mat.

○ **What would you have expected them to find? Say it before we go on.**

- And when they came back and said there was nothing, he did not relax. He brought the man closer, and watched him for twenty more years.

SAY THIS ONE TOGETHER

●○

**What was a caliph with
an army actually afraid
of?**



Then the hadith card.

IMAM AL-HADI SAID

**“This world is like a market in
which some profited and
others lost.”**

Imam al-Hadi

NOOR POST · THE FOURTEEN

The chain

Every card in this box is one link. Lay all fourteen in order and the chain runs from the Prophet to the last of the twelve, each one passing on what was given.



Fourteen segments · historical order

Tuhaf al-Uqul, short maxims, no. 15. Translated by Badr Shahin,
Ansariyan Publications, Qum.



The question

What was a caliph with an army actually afraid of?

Five evidence cards. Read them in any order. Then say your answer out loud, before anyone opens the sealed card.



EVIDENCE

1

The search was unannounced and at night. Nothing could have been prepared or hidden in advance.



EVIDENCE

2

They found no weapons, no plans, no money for an army, and nobody gathered. The soldiers reported that back.



EVIDENCE

3

After the search he was not released from attention. He was moved to Samarra, the garrison city, and kept there for about twenty years.



EVIDENCE

4

He had no army, no province, no treasury and no title from the state. Nothing that could be confiscated.



EVIDENCE

5

People travelled to Samarra to be near him from all over the empire, at their own expense, and got nothing material in return for going.



Sealed

Parent: open this only when the child has committed to an answer. Not before.



THE ANSWER

He was afraid of the thing you cannot take off somebody.

Everything a caliph knows how to deal with, he can seize. An army can be defeated. A treasury can be emptied. A province can be taken back. A rival with a title can be stripped of it.

None of that applies to a man on a mat. He has nothing to confiscate, so there is no move to make. And people are travelling across an empire to sit near him anyway, at their own cost, getting nothing they can carry home. That is loyalty that was never bought – which means it cannot be outbid.

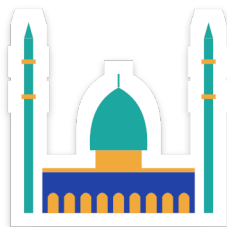
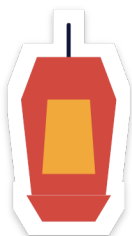
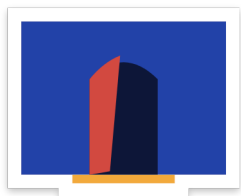
Look again at Evidence 2. The search finding nothing is not good news for the caliph. **It is the worst possible result.** If they had found weapons, he would finally have had a problem he understood, with a solution he had used a hundred times. Finding nothing proved the loyalty was not organised, not funded and not conditional.

And there is one more cost, in Evidence 1 and 2 together. He sent his own soldiers into that room at night, and they came back and told him what they had seen. **Men sent to find a conspirator came back as witnesses.** Every one of them now had a story to tell in the barracks.











**We opened this one
together.**

● _____

○ _____

Post it back to us, or keep it. Either is right.

STAMP

Noor Post

[Return address – not set]

